Praise of the Subduer of Māra

Toh 1117 · Derge Tengyur
བདུད་བཏུལ་བ་ལ་བསྟོད་པ

The Praise of the Subduer of Māra, in Tibetan Dü Tulwa la Töpa, is a brief hymn whose Tibetan version gives no Sanskrit title. In three long verses it celebrates the Buddha's victory over Māra on the eve of his awakening: the jealous women of Māra taunt him for a meditation they call false and heartless, Kāma and the hosts of Māra with their bows, drums and animal-faced warriors fail to shake his concentration, and the onlookers and siddhas bow in wonder before the Lord of Sages, the Protector of the World. Its colophon ascribes it to a royal author, named in Tibetan Rabgai Lha and identified as Harṣadeva, and its first two verses closely match the benedictions that open the Sanskrit drama Nāgānanda attributed to King Harṣa. It is Toh 1117 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the collection of hymns of praise (stotra).

Here is the Praise of the Subduer of Māra.

Homage to the Three Jewels.

"With this false meditative concentration, what are you contemplating? Just for a moment, open your eyes wide and look!
If even you, a protector, will not guard us, people tormented by the arrows of Anaṅga (the god of love),
Then you, compassionate one, have turned false; there is no other man more utterly cruel than you."
Though the jealous women of Māra spoke thus, the Victor, the Protector, attained awakening.

Moreover, the Lord of Desire (Kāma), his bow drawn to the full, and the other māras, swift of hand, with the sharp sound of paṭaha drums,
And the witnesses, their brows as if raised and quivering, without coquetry, smiles, or play,
Saw that the Lord of Sages, the Protector, could not be moved from meditative concentration until he had attained awakening;
And in amazement, their bodies bristling with hair on end, they bowed their heads together with the siddhas.

He whose mind was not thrown into confusion by those who swarmed on every side, matted locks disheveled and tongues flickering,

The radiant māras of the god of desire, the finest of points in their hands, with the faces of elephants and horses, of lions
And of tigers, countless as blades of grass, he whom their encircling host did not frighten:
He is the Buddha, who protects all with no trace of reproach mingled in, the Lord of Sages, the Protector of the World.

This completes the Praise of the Subduer of Māra, composed by His Majesty Harṣadeva.

Translator's Notes

• The first two verses correspond to the two benedictions that open King Harṣa's drama Nāgānanda; on that basis the author, named in Tibetan Rabgai Lha, "Joyful God", is identified as Harṣadeva, and □□□□□□□□ is rendered as the royal honorific "His Majesty". In the second verse □□□□□□, "the witnesses", and the phrase "without coquetry, smiles, or play" are translated as they stand, although the Sanskrit benediction speaks at this point of heavenly women glancing with frowns, trembling and smiles. In the third verse □□□□□, "covered", is read as □□□□, "flickering", of the demons' tongues, and □□□□ as □□□□□, "trace"; □□□□□□ is taken in its verbal sense, the host "encircling" the Buddha, not as saṃsāra.

Colophon

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Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.